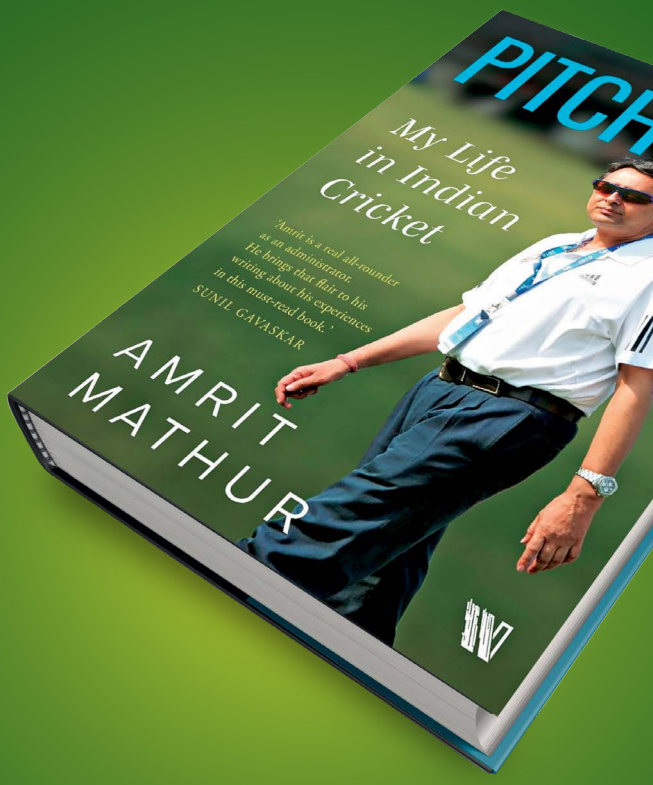
CRICKET

# An Insider's VIEW

**Amrit Mathur** illuminates key moments in Indian cricket in his unassuming and incisive memoir, *Pitchside*




Over the past year, the cricket boards of India and Pakistan have sparred endlessly: over India's participation in the Asia Cup and Pakistan's in the World Cup, creating an impression that the two countries have never been in sync where cricket relations are concerned. However, this is far removed from fact. True, there have been long and intense periods of dissonance, but these have been interspersed with several occasions of bonhomie and a deep spirit of accommodation for mutual benefit.

In fact, the three times the World Cup has been played in the subcontinent—1987, 1996 and 2011—the arch-rivals have been co-hosts. Given the protracted political discord between the two countries, what was the chemistry that made this possible?

Amrit Mathur highlights the fascinating give-and-take between the two countries—and the respective cricket boards—in clinching the right to host the 1996 World Cup. Winning the rights wasn't easy. It entailed countering the clout of the England, Australia, New Zealand caucus in the sport. Mathur, who fortuitously found a place in the Pakistan, India, Sri Lanka Joint Management Committee (PILCOM), relates that to win the rights, support of ICC's associate members became imperative. "To get associate ICC members on board, Indian-style election strategies were used. Various Indian and Pakistani origin people controlling cricket bodies were identified," he writes. This was followed by an emotional appeal that sought to give PILCOM's bid an anti-colonial, anti-racist angle. But that wasn't enough. Without putting more dosh than the other caucus on the table, the bid could have collapsed. Mathur reveals the commercial payout, offering larger guarantees to associate members while simultaneously cutting back on the share for Test playing nations. PILCOM also offered ICC a larger slice. "The political reverse swing worked," he writes. The 1996 World Cup was hugely successful. The tournament also saw the arrival of cable TV coverage of cricket in India. This was through Mark Mascarenhas's WorldTel, marking a major inflection point and gradually leading to India becoming a multi-billion-dollar cricketing nation.

**MATHUR HAS BEEN A CRICKET WRITER FOR FOUR DECADES, WHICH IS WHAT MAKES *PITCHSIDE* A DELECTABLE READ**

*Pitchside* is replete with such anecdotes because of Mathur's off-beat career, which every now and then put him in extraordinary situations. Educated at Mayo College, Ajmer and St Stephen's, Delhi, he played cricket at the university level, which explains his passion for and understanding of the game. His primary vocation was with the Indian Railways, but he's a man of many parts who has worn several hats, with cricket at the core. Apart from being part of the 1996 World Cup organising committee, he was manager on the epochal tour of South Africa in 1992, shortly after Nelson Mandela was released from incarceration, manager of the team again in the 2003 World Cup, media manager when India toured Pakistan in 2004, and was associated with Delhi Daredevils in the IPL.